

Incendiary substances

US chemical warfare in Vietnam also involved incendiary devices—ostensibly designed to burn structures but also highly effective against people. Essentially jellied gasoline, napalm is chemically engineered to stick to its target; it burns incredibly hot and rapidly deoxygenates the air, suffocating people caught in confined spaces.

In Vietnam, the US Air Force dropped napalm bombs over villages or forests sheltering enemy combatants, resulting in massive orange fireballs. Soldiers also used napalm in flamethrowers to target bunkers and tunnels. White phosphorus, an incendiary and smoke-producing agent, was also used in Vietnam. Its distinctive white plumes were useful as markers and smokescreens. Like herbicides, incendiaries were effective but controversial, because they led to untreatable wounds. White phosphorus would continue to burn until it was completely deprived of oxygen, resulting in horrific burns and lethal poisoning.

Incendiaries did not discriminate between civilians and insurgents hiding in their midst. This resulted in thousands of civilian casualties, who overwhelmed the South Vietnamese health service. Both napalm and white phosphorus resulted in wounds that the human body was not equipped to heal, so their victims were usually left to die, untreated, in order for scarce medical resources to be directed toward those with a better chance of survival.